Flourish
LEGAL WELL-BEING

Supporting a Colleague Who Approaches You About Mental Health

It can be challenging when a colleague opens up to you about mental health struggles. Knowing how to respond with care and understanding can make all the difference.

Use Active Listening

- Put your phone away, make eye contact, and let them know they have your full attention.
- Mirror their words to show you're listening. ("It sounds like you've been feeling...")

Clarify What They Need

- Before jumping into problem-solving, ask, "Do you want to be helped or just heard?"
- Sometimes, people just want some empathy, not advice.

Ask Open-Ended Questions

- Encourage them to share more without pushing.

Good questions:

- "What's on your mind?"
- "What about that feels important to you?"
- "Why is that?"
- "How can I support you right now?"

Manage Your Own Emotions

- Take a few slow breaths or use a grounding technique (like feeling the sensation of your feet on the floor) to stay calm.
- Being emotionally regulated helps you be a better listener.

Offer Next Steps If Appropriate

- If they want help, offer to talk with someone on their behalf or connect them with resources (HR, the org's Employee Assistance Program, an external therapist, etc.).